

ETS review proposal keeps sparking criticism

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By MARTINA SAPIO with TOMMASO LECCA SNEAK PEEK — The Commission's proposal to r

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

By MARTINA SAPIO

with TOMMASO LECCA

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SNEAK PEEK

— The Commission’s proposal to review the Emissions Trading System continues to draw fire from the aviation industry and, for very different reasons, the German government.

— Ukraine’s reported strike on an Iranian commercial vessel in the Caspian Sea suggests the maritime war is expanding beyond the Black Sea.

— Mercedes-Benz says demand for its new electric models is accelerating despite a tougher market in China.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

ASIAN AIRLINES JOIN CRITICISM OF ETS REVIEW PROPOSAL: More than 10 days after the European Commission unveiled its proposal to review the Emissions Trading System, the text continues to face pushback from multiple sides. The proposed extension of the ETS to additional aviation routes landing within 5,000 kilometers of Frankfurt Airport remains very contentious.

East vs. ETS: The Association of Asia Pacific Airlines warned Tuesday that “a unilateral, regional extension of EU ETS risks setting a precedent for fragmented, extraterritorial climate measures that could undermine this multilateral framework over time,” referring to the U.N.’s Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation.

Thanks, but no thanks: The criticism comes even though the Commission decided to keep exempting most long-haul flights, including journeys to destinations across much of the Asia-Pacific region.

In line with ICAO: The Kuala Lumpur-based lobby echoed concerns previously raised by the U.N.’s International Civil Aviation Organization, warning that an expanded ETS could undermine CORSIA and “risks duplicative measures.” It also urged EU co-legislators to reaffirm their support for CORSIA during upcoming negotiations.

No comment, no assessment: Contacted by Morning Mobility, the Commission did not comment on AAPA's statement. As July draws to a close, the Commission has also yet to publish its full assessment of CORSIA, which had originally been expected by July 1.

More complaints: For very different reasons, the proposal also came under fire Tuesday from Jochen Flasbarth, Germany's state secretary at the environment ministry. Speaking to our Berlin-based colleagues, Flasbarth argued that the ETS review aims for only an 88 percent reduction in CO2 emissions by 2040, falling short of the EU's agreed 90 percent climate target.

Not enough: "Emissions trading should be geared toward a 90 percent reduction in emissions, with up to 5 percentage points of that serving as a safety net through international credits — in other words, an additional option," Flasbarth said.

Starting in 2036, the Commission also plans to allow industry, for the first time, to use international carbon credits to help meet part of its emissions reduction obligations. The measure is intended to help achieve the EU's overall target of cutting all emissions by 90 percent by 2040.

See you in negotiations: "Both from the perspective of climate impact and from an economic standpoint, we will have to discuss this in the negotiations with the Commission — and, of course, in the Council," Flasbarth said, signaling that negotiations on the broader proposal are likely to be contentious.

Maritime troubles: There are also grumbles over the maritime chapter. While shippers have generally welcomed plans to earmark ETS revenues for shipping decarbonization, Dutch digital port platform PortXchange argues the proposal overlooks one of the biggest opportunities to cut emissions: ports. The company says Brussels has focused on alternative fuels and onboard technologies while failing to support investments in port-call optimization, voyage planning and digital coordination that could reduce waiting times, congestion and emissions from existing ships.

MARITIME

MARITIME WAR SPREADING: Ukraine's reported strike on an Iranian vessel in the Caspian Sea that Kyiv said was carrying arms to Russia is raising worries about an expansion of the maritime war.

A wider campaign: Conflict monitor ACLED said the strike should be seen as an effort to disrupt logistics networks supporting Russia's war. It follows months of intensified Ukrainian attacks on Russia's oil infrastructure and maritime assets, including drone strikes on nearly 200 Russian and Russia-linked tankers, cargo vessels and tugboats in the Black and Azov Seas during July.

Not a one-off? Speaking to Israeli broadcaster N12, Ukraine's ambassador to Israel, Yevgen Korniychuk, said the vessel was carrying drone and missile components rather than civilian cargo and described it as a legitimate military target. He also suggested similar operations could follow, saying: "You can expect us to strike them again." Iran has condemned the attack, warning it could further escalate the conflict.

Europe has seen this before: In March, Moscow accused Ukraine of attacking a Russian LNG tanker in the central Mediterranean. The damaged carrier drifted for days, prompting Malta and Italy to coordinate contingency plans over navigation safety, salvage operations and the risk of an environmental disaster. The incident also exposed legal questions over whether EU companies could assist a sanctioned Russian vessel.

Russia adapts: The attacks may also be reshaping Russian shipping. According to media reports, Moscow is considering naval escorts of grain vessels in the Sea of Azov while fitting ships with

machine-gun mounts and anti-drone protection. At the same time, it has begun sending some fully laden oil tankers via the Northern Sea Route, according to navigational data . That would allow Moscow to bypass European waters, avoiding the risk of detention by allied countries and reducing exposure to drone attacks. Russia has also retaliated by hitting the Ukrainian port of Odesa.

CARS

MERCEDES BETS ON EVS AND DEFENCE: Mercedes-Benz says demand for its new electric models is accelerating despite a tougher market in China, while also expanding into defence as Europe's largest carmakers adapt to the continent's rearmament drive. The company on Tuesday reported second-quarter operating profit of €1.55 billion, up 22 percent from €1.27 billion a year earlier. Revenue fell by 3 percent to €32.1 billion from €33.2 billion.

Europe drives the EV push: Battery-electric vehicle sales jumped 51 percent globally in the second quarter and 87 percent in Europe, prompting Mercedes to raise its forecast for electrified vehicles to account for about a quarter of passenger car sales this year.

China remains the weak spot: Passenger car sales in China fell 30 percent thanks to intense competition and weaker demand, contributing to a €704 million impairment on the company's Chinese joint ventures. Mercedes now expects overall passenger car sales and group revenue to come in slightly below last year's levels.

Defense opportunity: Mercedes also announced plans to deepen its activities in the security and defense sector, signing a memorandum of understanding with German company Tytan to explore military applications based on the G-Class and Sprinter. The cooperation will examine counter-drone systems, mobile drone carriers and command vehicles, reflecting growing demand as European governments ramp up defense spending.

AVIATION

CHARLEROI CLOSURE SPARKS UNCERTAINTY FOR PASSENGERS: The planned 11-week closure of Charleroi airport between August and October 2028 is raising questions not only about its impact on jobs, but also about what happens to the thousands of passengers who use Belgium's second-busiest airport every day.

Are you one of them? The airport, served mainly by low-cost carriers Ryanair and Wizz Air, handled 11.2 million passengers last year, meaning an 11-week closure could affect more than 2 million travelers, Tommaso reports . To avoid losing all that traffic, airlines are likely to look for alternative airports.

From Charleroi to Zaventem? "While it may seem natural that Brussels [Airport] will be a beneficiary, I would also expect Lille, around 45 minutes drive away, to see a growth in traffic," said air transport consultant John Strickland. Zaventem's Brussels Airport did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The closure is "clearly not ideal but equally an operational necessity and by giving such a lengthy notice period airlines operating to the airport can plan accordingly," John Grant, an analyst at Midas Aviation, told our colleague Gerardo Fortuna. "For travelers there are always alternate choices although sometimes with increased cost implications."

BOEING RESULTS SPARK MIXED REACTIONS: Boeing's quarterly results released Tuesday drew mixed reactions from analysts, largely because of mounting costs for the new Air Force One program for U.S. President Donald Trump, but were broadly welcomed by investors. The aircraft manufacturer reported \$24.6 billion in revenue, reflecting 171 commercial aircraft deliveries, and generated more than \$600 million in free cash flow — well above the \$177 million expected by analysts.

Air Force losses: Boeing also booked \$280 million in additional charges related to the two new Air Force One aircraft. The program, negotiated during Trump's first administration, was originally capped at \$3.9 billion in 2018 but has since risen to \$4.5 billion. The \$280 million additional costs were "primarily driven by an investment in additional production and certification resources," Boeing said. Despite the latest overruns, the company said it still expects to deliver the first aircraft in 2028.

PIT STOPS

The war with Iran and Trump's tariffs are creating a shipping boom, CMA CGM Group said when releasing its second-quarter results on Tuesday, announcing a 19 percent increase in revenues to \$15.7 billion.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Allies shrug as US pushes for Strait of Hormuz patrol

The Trump administration is urging the U.K. and France to lead a naval coalition to secure the strait, but allies want to see a ceasefire first.

By Paul McLeary, Esther Webber · Jul 28, 2026, 10:53 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Charleroi airport to halt flights in 2028 for over 2 months

The suspension is necessary to allow major reconstruction works on the hub's only runway.

By Tommaso Lecca · Jul 28, 2026, 01:55 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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